

INTRODUCTION

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I. General Features of Japanese

1. Parts of Speech

The Japanese language is comprised of verbs, adjectives, nouns, adverbs, conjunctions and particles.

2. Word Order

A predicate always comes at the end of a sentence. A modifier always comes before the word or phrase to be modified.

3. Predicate

There are three types of predicates in Japanese: noun, verb and adjective. A predicate inflects according to whether it is (1) affirmative or negative and (2) non-past or past.

Adjectives are divided into two types according to their type of inflection.

They are called い-adjectives and な-adjectives.

In Japanese, words do not inflect for person, gender or number.

4. Particle

A particle is used to show the grammatical relation between words, to show the speaker's intention or to connect sentences.

5. Omission

Words or phrases are often omitted if they are understood from the context.

Even the subject and object of a sentence are often omitted.

II. Japanese Script

There are three kinds of letters in Japanese: hiragana, katakana and kanji (Chinese characters). Hiragana and katakana are phonetic representations of sounds, and each letter basically corresponds to one mora (a unit of sound. See III). Kanji convey meanings as well as sounds.

In Japanese script, all three types of letters are used together. Katakana are used to write foreign names and loan words. 1945 kanji letters are fixed as essential for daily use. Hiragana are used to write particles, the inflectable parts of words, etc. Other than these three types of letters, romaji (Roman letters) are sometimes used for the convenience of foreigners. You may see romaji at stations and on sign-boards. Below are examples of all four types of script.

田中 さん は ミラー さん と デパート へ 行 きます。
○ □ □ △ □ □ △ □ ○ □

Mr. Tanaka is going to the department store with Mr. Miller.

大阪 O s a k a
○ ☆
(○ - kanji □ - hiragana △ - katakana ☆ - romaji)

3

The Japanese language is based on five vowel sounds: あ (a), い (i), う (u), え (e) and お (o) (see the table on the previous page). All spoken sounds are derived from these five vowels. They are used alone or are attached to either a consonant (e.g., k + a = か) or a consonant plus the semi-vowel "y" (e.g., k + y + a = きゃ). The exception to this is a special mora, ん (n), which is not followed by vowels. All of these sounds are of equal length when spoken.

[Note 1] A mora is a unit of sound in Japanese.

[Note 2] In order to write the Japanese language according to the pronunciation, kana are used. (See "Kana and Mora" on the previous page.) One kana letter or one kana letter accompanied by a small kana letter (e.g., きゃ) basically corresponds to one mora.

2. Long Vowels

A long vowel is pronounced twice as long as the ordinary vowels あ, い, う, え and お. If you count the length of the vowel あ as one, the length of the long vowel ああ is counted as two. This means あ is one mora long, whereas ああ is two moras long.

Whether a vowel is long or not can change the meaning of the word.

e.g., おばさん (aunt): おばあさん (grandmother)
おじさん (uncle): おじいさん (grandfather)
ゆき (snow): ゆうき (courage)
え (picture): ええ (yes) とる (take): とおる (pass)
ここ (here): こうこう (high school) へや (room): へいや (plain)
カード (card) タクシー (taxi) スーパー (supermarket)
テープ (tape) ノート (notebook)

[Note]

1) How to write the long vowels in hiragana

(1) The long vowels of the あ-line

Add あ to the hiragana letters belonging to the あ-line.

(2) The long vowels of the い-line

Add い to the hiragana letters belonging to the い-line.

(3) The long vowels of the う-line

Add う to the hiragana letters belonging to the う-line.

(4) The long vowels of the え-line

Add い to the hiragana letters belonging to the え-line.

(exceptions: ええ yes, ねえ say, おねえさん elder sister)

(5) The long vowels of the お-line

Add う to the hiragana letters belonging to the お-line.

(exceptions: おおきい big, おおい many, とおい far, and some others)

III. Pronunciation of Japanese

1. Kana and Mora

	あ-line	い-line	う-line	え-line	お-line
あ-row	あア a	いイ i	うウ u	えエ e	おオ o
か-row	かカ ka	きキ ki	くク ku	けケ ke	こコ ko
さ-row	さサ sa	しシ shi	すス su	せセ se	そソ so
た-row	たタ ta	ちチ chi	つツ tsu	てテ te	とト to
な-row	なナ na	にニ ni	ぬヌ nu	ねネ ne	のノ no
は-row	はハ ha	ひヒ hi	ふフ fu	へヘ he	ほホ ho
ま-row	まマ ma	みミ mi	むム mu	めメ me	もモ mo
や-row	やヤ ya	(いイ) (i)	ゆユ yu	(えエ) (e)	よヨ yo
ら-row	らラ ra	りリ ri	るル ru	れレ re	ろロ ro
わ-row	わワ wa	(いイ) (i)	(うウ) (u)	(えエ) (e)	をヲ o
	んン n				

e.g.,

あア	hiragana script
カ	katakana script
a	the Roman alphabet

きゃキャ kya	きゅキュ kyu	きょキョ kyo
しゃシャ sha	しゅシュ shu	しょショ sho
ちゃチャ cha	ちゅチュ chu	ちょチョ cho
にゃニャ nya	にゅニュ nyu	にょニョ nyo
ひゃヒャ hya	ひゅヒュ hyu	ひょヒョ hyo
みゃミャ mya	みゅミュ myu	みょミョ myo

りゃリャ rya	りゅリュ ryu	りょリョ ryo
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が-row g	ガガ ga	ギギ gi	ググ gu	ゲゲ ge	ゴゴ go
ざ-row z	ザザ za	ジジ ji	ズズ zu	ゼゼ ze	ゾゾ zo
だ-row d	ダダ da	ヂヂ ji	ヅヅ zu	デデ de	ドド do
ば-row b	ババ ba	ビビ bi	ブブ bu	ベベ be	ボボ bo
ぱ-row p	パパ pa	ピピ pi	ププ pu	ペペ pe	ポポ po

ギャギャ gya	ギュギュ gyu	ギョギョ gyo
ジャジャ ja	ジュジュ ju	ジョジョ jo

ビャビャ bya	ビュビュ byu	ビョビョ byo
ピャピャ pya	ピュピュ pyu	ピョピョ pyo

The katakana letters in the square on the right are not in the above table. They are used to write sounds which are not original Japanese sounds but are needed for use in loan words.

ウィ wi	ウェ we	ウォ wo
ツァ tsa	シェ she	チェ che
ティ ti	ツェ tse	ツォ tso
ファイ fi	フェ fe	フォ fo
ディ di	ジェ je	
ドウ du		
デュ dyu		

あ		あ	あ						
い		い	い						
う		う	う						
え		え	え						
お		お	お						
か		か	か						
き		き	き						
く		く	く						
け		け	け						
こ		こ	こ						
さ		さ	さ						
し		し	し						
す		す	す						
せ		せ	せ						
そ		そ	そ						
た		た	た						
ち		ち	ち						
つ		つ	つ						
て		て	て						
と		と	と						

i

u

e

O

ka

ki

ku

ke

ko

sa

shì

su

se

so

ta

chi

tsu

te

to

na

な な な な

ni

に に に に

nu

ぬ ぬ ぬ

ne

ね ね ね

no

の の

ha

は は は は

hi

ひ ひ ひ

hu

ふ ふ ふ ふ

he

へ へ

ho

ほ ほ ほ ほ

ma

ま ま ま ま

mi

み み み

mu

む む む む

me

め め め

mo

も も も も

ya

や や や や

yu

ゆ ゆ ゆ

yo

よ よ よ

ra

[illegible]

ri

[illegible]

ru

[illegible]

re

[illegible]

ro

[illegible]

wa

わ

WO

[illegible]

n

4. 1

Hiragana Chart

	a	i	u	e	o
	あ	い	う	え	お
k	か ka	き ki	く ku	け ke	こ ko
s	さ sa	し shi	す su	せ se	そ so
t	た ta	ち chi	つ tsu	て te	と to
h	は ha	ひ hi	ふ hu/fu	へ he	ほ ho
m	ま ma	み mi	む mu	め me	も mo
y	や ya		ゆ yu		よ yo
r	ら ra	り ri	る ru	れ re	ろ ro
w	わ wa				を wo
	ん n				

	a	i	u	e	o
g	が g a	ぎ g i	ぐ g u	げ g e	ご g o
z	ざ z a	じ j i	ず z u	ぜ z e	ぞ z o
d	だ d a			で d e	ど d o
b	ば b a	び b i	ぶ b u	べ b e	ぼ b o
p	ぱ p a	ぴ p i	ぷ p u	ぺ p e	ぽ p o

Lesson 1

I. Vocabulary

わたし	watashi	I
わたしたち	watashi tachi	we
あなた	anata	you
あのひと	ano hito	that person, he, she
(あのかた)	(あの方)	(あのかた is the polite equivalent of あのひと)
みなさん	minasan	ladies and gentlemen, all of you
皆さん	皆さん	
～さん	—san	Mr., Ms. (title of respect added to a name)
～ちゃん	—chan	(suffix often added to a child's name instead of ～さん)
～くん	—kun	(suffix often added to a boy's name)
～じん	—jin	(suffix meaning "a national of"; e.g., アメリカじん, an American)
～人	～人	
せんせい	sensei	teacher, instructor (not used when referring to one's own job)
先生	先生	
きょうし	kyoushi	teacher, instructor
がくせい	gakusei	student
学生	学生	
かいしゃいん	kaishain	company employee
しゃいん	shain	employee of ~ Company (used with a company's name; e.g., IMCのしゃいん)
社員	社員	
ぎんこういん	ginkouin	bank employee
銀行員	銀行員	
いしや	isha	medical doctor
医者	医者	
けんきゅうしゃ	kenkyuusha	researcher, scholar
研究者	研究者	
エンジニア	enjinia	engineer
だいがく	daigaku	university, college
大学	大学	
びょういん	byouin	hospital
病院	病院	
でんき	denki	electricity, light
電気	電気	
だれ (どなた)	dare (donata)	who (どなた is the polite equivalent of だれ)

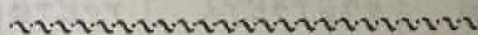
-さい -sai 一歳
 なんさい nan sai 何歳
 (おいくつ) (oikutsu)
 - years old
 how old (おいくつ is the polite equivalent of なんさい)

はい hai
 いいえ iie
 yes
 no

しつれいですが 失礼ですが Excuse me, but shitsurei desu ga
 おなまえは? お名前は? May I have your name? onamae wa?
 はじめまして。 初めまして。 How do you do? (lit. I am meeting you for
 hajimemashite the first time. Usually used as the first
 phrase when introducing oneself.)

douzo yoroshiku (onegaishimasu)
 どうぞ よろしく [おねがいします]。 Pleased to meet you. (lit. Please be nice
 どうぞ よろしく [お願いします]。 to me. Usually used at the end of a
 self-introduction.)

kochira wa —san desu
 こちらは ~さんです。 This is Mr./Ms. ~.
 ~から きました。 —kara kimashita I came (come) from ~.
 ~から 来ました。



アメリカ amerika	U.S.A.
イギリス igirisu	U.K.
インド indo	India
インドネシア indonesia	Indonesia
韓国 kankoku	South Korea
タイ tai	Thailand
中国 chuugoku	China
ドイツ doitsu	Germany
日本 nihon , nippon	Japan
フランス furansu	France
ブラジル burajiru	Brazil
さくら大学 / 富士大学 sakura daigaku	fictitious universities h(f)uji daigaku
IMC / パワー電気 / ブラジルエアー pawaa denki / burajiru eaa	fictitious companies
AKC	fictitious institute
神戸病院 koube byouin	fictitious hospital

IV. Grammar Explanation

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1. **N₁ は N₂ です**

1) Particle は

The particle は indicates that the word before it is the topic of the sentence. You select a noun you want to talk about, add は to show that it is the topic and give a statement about the topic.

① わたしは マイク・ミラーです。

I am Mike Miller.

[Note] The particle は is read わ.

2) です

Nouns used with です work as predicates.

です indicates judgement or assertion.

です also conveys that the speaker is being polite towards the listener.

です inflects when the sentence is negative (see 2. below) or in the past tense (see Lesson 12).

② わたしは エンジニアです。

I am an engineer.

2. **N₁ は N₂ じゃありません**

じゃ ありません is the negative form of です. It is the form used in daily conversation. For a formal speech or writing, では ありません is used instead.

③ サントスさんは 学生じゃ ありません。 Mr. Santos is not a student.
(では)

[Note] は in では is read わ.

3. **S か**

1) Particle か

The particle か is used to express the speaker's doubt, question, uncertainty, etc. A question is formed by simply adding か to the end of the sentence. A question ends with a rising intonation.

2) Questions asking whether a statement is correct or not

As mentioned above, a sentence becomes a question when か is added to the end. The word order does not change. The question thus made asks whether a statement is correct or not. Depending on whether you agree with the statement or not, your answer to such a question begins with はい or いいえ.

④ ミラーさんは アメリカ人ですか。

Is Mr. Miller an American?

…はい、アメリカ人です。

…Yes, he is.

⑤ ミラーさんは 先生ですか。

Is Mr. Miller a teacher?

…いいえ、先生じゃ ありません。

…No, he is not.

3) Questions with interrogatives

An interrogative replaces the part of the sentence that covers what you want to ask about. The word order does not change, and か is added at the end.

⑥ あの 方は どなたですか。

Who is that man?

… [あの 方は] ミラーさんです。

…That's Mr. Miller.

4. **N も**

も is added after a topic instead of は when the statement about the topic is the same as the previous topic.

- ⑦ ミラーさんは 会社員です。 Mr. Miller is a company employee.
グプタさんも 会社員です。 Mr. Gupta is also a company employee.

5. **N₁ の N₂**

の is used to connect two nouns. N₁ modifies N₂. In Lesson 1, N₁ is an organization or some kind of group to which N₂ belongs.

- ⑧ ミラーさんは IMC の 社員です。 Mr. Miller is an IMC employee.

6. **～さん**

さん is added to the name of the listener or a third person to show the speaker's respect to the person. It should never be used with the speaker's own name.

- ⑨ あの方 は ミラーさんです。 That's Mr. Miller.

When referring directly to the listener, the word あなた (you) is not commonly used if you know the listener's name. The listener's family name followed by さん is usually used.

- ⑩ 鈴木: ミラーさんは 学生ですか

ミラー: いいえ、会社員です。

Suzuki: Are you a student?

Miller: No, I'm a company employee.